Academic Research Paper

CSN Sociology — SOC 101

100 pts

Unit 2 — Word Processing · Variation Project Option A

/ 100 points

How to use this instruction sheet: Download the starter file from the Project Grader, open it in Microsoft Word 365, and keep this sheet open beside it. Work through each task in order. Each task tells you what to do, why it matters, and where to find the tool — but you must figure out the exact steps yourself. That's the learning.

Screen Recording Requirement

To verify your own work, record yourself completing 3 tasks while working on this project.

- Use Xbox Game Bar (press Win+G) or Loom (loom.com — free account) to record your screen
- Show yourself completing any 3 tasks from the list below
- Submit the recording to Canvas along with your completed file

D1 — Manage Documents

22 points (10 tasks)

2

Task 1 — Set 1-inch margins on all sides (APA standard)

WHY THIS MATTERS

APA format requires 1-inch margins on all sides. This is a non-negotiable standard for academic papers submitted for grading.

WHERE TO FIND IT

Layout tab → Margins → Custom Margins → set all four sides to exactly 1".

HOW YOU'LL KNOW IT WORKED

The ruler shows the text area starting at exactly 1" from each edge.

2

Task 2 — Set page orientation to Portrait

WHY THIS MATTERS

Academic research papers are always Portrait orientation. Landscape is only used for wide figures or tables in an appendix.

WHERE TO FIND IT

Layout tab → Orientation → Portrait.

HOW YOU'LL KNOW IT WORKED

All pages are taller than wide (standard 8.5" × 11").

2

Task 3 — Apply the "Basic (Simple)" style set

WHY THIS MATTERS

The Basic (Simple) style set uses clean, minimal typography appropriate for academic writing without decorative design elements.

WHERE TO FIND IT

Design tab → Document Formatting group → Style Sets gallery → "Basic (Simple)".

HOW YOU'LL KNOW IT WORKED

The document uses clean, minimal fonts for headings and body text.

3

Task 4 — Insert a running head in the header: title left-aligned, page number right-aligned

WHY THIS MATTERS

APA format requires a running head (shortened title) on the left and page number on the right of every page header.

WHERE TO FIND IT

Insert → Header → Edit Header. Type the paper title (shortened if long) left-aligned. Tab twice to the right and insert a page number.

HOW YOU'LL KNOW IT WORKED

Every page shows the paper title on the left and the page number on the right of the header.

2

Task 5 — Insert page numbers in the top-right corner of the header

WHY THIS MATTERS

APA format places page numbers in the top-right corner of every page, including the title page.

WHERE TO FIND IT

While editing the header, place cursor on the right side. Header & Footer tab → Page Number → Current Position → choose a right-aligned style.

HOW YOU'LL KNOW IT WORKED

Page numbers appear in the top-right corner of every page.

2

Task 6 — Set document properties: Title, Author (your name), Subject

WHY THIS MATTERS

Document properties record authorship and subject matter, which is important for academic integrity and file organization.

WHERE TO FIND IT

File → Info → Properties panel on the right → fill in Title, Author (your name), and Subject.

HOW YOU'LL KNOW IT WORKED

File → Info shows your name as Author and the paper title as Title.

2

Task 7 — Use the Go To feature to navigate directly to page 5

WHY THIS MATTERS

Go To lets you jump to a specific page number instantly in long documents, which is faster than scrolling.

WHERE TO FIND IT

Press Ctrl+G (or F5) to open the Go To dialog. Make sure "Page" is selected. Type 5 in the Enter page number box. Click Go To.

HOW YOU'LL KNOW IT WORKED

The document jumps to page 5 immediately.

2

Task 8 — Use Find to locate all instances of "social media" in the document

WHY THIS MATTERS

Find shows you every place a term appears, which is useful for reviewing consistency of usage before submission.

WHERE TO FIND IT

Press Ctrl+F to open the Navigation Pane. Type "social media" in the search box. All matches are highlighted.

HOW YOU'LL KNOW IT WORKED

The Navigation Pane shows the number of matches found and highlights each instance in the document.

2

Task 9 — Run a Compatibility Check before submitting the file

WHY THIS MATTERS

Compatibility Check ensures your document will open correctly if the recipient uses an older version of Word.

WHERE TO FIND IT

File → Info → Check for Issues → Check Compatibility. Review the results.

HOW YOU'LL KNOW IT WORKED

The Compatibility Checker dialog opens and lists any compatibility issues (or confirms none were found).

3

Task 10 — Save as both a .docx file and a separate PDF copy

WHY THIS MATTERS

Submitting both formats ensures the instructor can open the file for grading and also see your exact formatting in the PDF.

WHERE TO FIND IT

Save as .docx normally (Ctrl+S). Then File → Save As → change type to PDF → Save. You should have two files: one .docx and one .pdf.

HOW YOU'LL KNOW IT WORKED

Two files exist in your folder — one ending in .docx and one ending in .pdf.

D2 — Format Text & Paragraphs

20 points (8 tasks)

2

Task 11 — Use Find & Replace to replace all abbreviations "SM" with "social media"

WHY THIS MATTERS

Academic papers should not use informal abbreviations. The starter file uses "SM" as a shorthand that must be expanded for submission.

WHERE TO FIND IT

Ctrl+H → Find What: SM → Replace With: social media → Replace All.

HOW YOU'LL KNOW IT WORKED

No instances of " SM " remain in the body text (check for the abbreviation with spaces around it to avoid replacing words containing SM).

2

Task 12 — Apply the Title style to the paper title on the title page

WHY THIS MATTERS

Using the built-in Title style ensures consistent, APA-appropriate formatting for the main title.

WHERE TO FIND IT

Click on the paper title → Home tab → Styles → Title.

HOW YOU'LL KNOW IT WORKED

The paper title displays in a large, styled format distinctly different from body text.

3

Task 13 — Apply Heading 1 to each major section: Introduction, Literature Review, Methodology, Results, Conclusion, References

WHY THIS MATTERS

APA research papers use section headings to organize content. Heading 1 creates the primary level and enables automatic TOC generation.

WHERE TO FIND IT

Click each section heading → Home tab → Styles → Heading 1. Repeat for all 6 major sections.

HOW YOU'LL KNOW IT WORKED

All six major sections use the same Heading 1 formatting. They appear as top-level items in the Navigation Pane.

3

Task 14 — Apply Heading 2 to all subsections within each major section

WHY THIS MATTERS

Heading 2 creates the second level of hierarchy, allowing readers to navigate within sections.

WHERE TO FIND IT

Click each subsection heading → Home tab → Styles → Heading 2.

HOW YOU'LL KNOW IT WORKED

Subsection headings appear in a smaller, distinct format below their Heading 1 parent in the Navigation Pane.

2

Task 15 — Set the entire document to double spacing (2.0)

WHY THIS MATTERS

APA requires double spacing throughout the entire paper, including block quotes, references, and figure captions.

WHERE TO FIND IT

Ctrl+A to select all → Home tab → Line and Paragraph Spacing button → 2.0.

HOW YOU'LL KNOW IT WORKED

There is a full blank line height between every line of text throughout the document.

2

Task 16 — Set a 0.5-inch first-line indent on all body paragraphs

WHY THIS MATTERS

APA requires the first line of every body paragraph (except the abstract) to be indented 0.5 inches.

WHERE TO FIND IT

Select body text paragraphs → Home tab → Paragraph dialog launcher (small arrow) → Indentation → Special: First Line → By: 0.5".

HOW YOU'LL KNOW IT WORKED

Each body paragraph's first line starts 0.5 inches to the right of the left margin.

3

Task 17 — Apply the "Intense Quote" character style to the direct quotation in the Literature Review

WHY THIS MATTERS

Character styles apply formatting to selected text within a paragraph. Intense Quote visually distinguishes a direct quotation from surrounding text.

WHERE TO FIND IT

Select only the quotation text. Home tab → Styles → find "Intense Quote" in the styles gallery (you may need to expand it). Click to apply.

HOW YOU'LL KNOW IT WORKED

The selected quotation text changes appearance (usually becomes italic and/or a different color) while surrounding text remains unchanged.

3

Task 18 — Insert a page break before the References section

WHY THIS MATTERS

APA requires the References section to start on a new page, separate from the conclusion.

WHERE TO FIND IT

Place cursor just before the References heading. Insert tab → Pages group → Page Break. Or press Ctrl+Enter.

HOW YOU'LL KNOW IT WORKED

The References section begins at the top of a new page.

D3 — Tables & Lists

14 points (6 tasks)

3

Task 19 — Create a 4-column table to display the survey results data

WHY THIS MATTERS

Survey data (Information Source | Respondents | Response % | Rank) is most readable in a table with clearly labeled columns.

WHERE TO FIND IT

Position cursor in the Results section. Insert tab → Table → select 4 columns and enough rows for all survey items.

HOW YOU'LL KNOW IT WORKED

A 4-column table appears. You can type data into each cell.

2

Task 20 — Merge the top row cells to create a single title spanning the full width

WHY THIS MATTERS

A merged title row identifies what the table contains, following APA table formatting guidelines.

WHERE TO FIND IT

Select all 4 cells in row 1. Table Layout tab → Merge → Merge Cells. Type the table title.

HOW YOU'LL KNOW IT WORKED

Row 1 is a single wide cell. The title spans the full table width.

2

Task 21 — Sort the data rows by Response % from highest to lowest (descending)

WHY THIS MATTERS

Sorting by percentage puts the most influential information source first, making the data's conclusion immediately visible.

WHERE TO FIND IT

Click in the table. Table Layout tab → Data group → Sort. Select the Response % column. Choose Descending.

HOW YOU'LL KNOW IT WORKED

The row with the highest percentage (78%) appears first, and items decrease from there.

2

Task 22 — Create a numbered list of Research Questions for Study 1

WHY THIS MATTERS

Research questions are conventionally numbered so they can be referenced specifically (e.g., "Research Question 1 examines...").

WHERE TO FIND IT

Type each research question on its own line. Select all. Home tab → Numbering button.

HOW YOU'LL KNOW IT WORKED

Research questions are numbered 1, 2, 3 with consistent formatting.

2

Task 23 — Create a bulleted list of key findings

WHY THIS MATTERS

Key findings presented as bullets let readers quickly scan and absorb the most important results without reading full paragraphs.

WHERE TO FIND IT

Type each finding. Select all. Home tab → Bullets button.

HOW YOU'LL KNOW IT WORKED

Each finding has a bullet point. All bullets are the same style.

3

Task 24 — Restart the list numbering for the second set of Research Questions (Study 2)

WHY THIS MATTERS

Study 2's research questions should be numbered starting from 1, not continuing from Study 1's numbering.

WHERE TO FIND IT

Right-click the first item of the Study 2 list → Restart at 1. Or go to Home tab → Numbering dropdown → Set Numbering Value.

HOW YOU'LL KNOW IT WORKED

The Study 2 research questions start from 1 even though Study 1 already used 1, 2, 3.

D4 — References

10 points (3 tasks)

3

Task 25 — Insert an automatic Table of Contents after the title page

WHY THIS MATTERS

A TOC helps readers navigate the paper and demonstrates that your heading structure is correctly applied.

WHERE TO FIND IT

Place cursor on a blank page after the title page. References tab → Table of Contents → choose an Automatic style.

HOW YOU'LL KNOW IT WORKED

A TOC appears with all section and subsection headings and page numbers.

3

Task 26 — Customize the TOC to show only Heading 1 and Heading 2 levels

WHY THIS MATTERS

Showing 2 levels in a research paper TOC is standard. More levels would clutter the navigation.

WHERE TO FIND IT

References → Table of Contents → Custom Table of Contents → Show levels: 2 → OK.

HOW YOU'LL KNOW IT WORKED

The TOC shows only major sections and their subsections, not any deeper levels.

4

Task 27 — Insert 5 footnotes throughout the paper citing your sources

WHY THIS MATTERS

Footnotes in APA style cite specific claims with source references, giving credit and enabling readers to verify information.

WHERE TO FIND IT

Place cursor after each fact/claim you want to cite. References tab → Footnotes group → Insert Footnote. Type the citation at the bottom of that page.

HOW YOU'LL KNOW IT WORKED

5 superscript numbers appear in the paper body, each with a corresponding citation at the bottom of its page.

D5 — Graphic Elements

20 points (7 tasks)

3

Task 28 — Insert a bar chart screenshot showing the survey data

WHY THIS MATTERS

APA research papers include figures to present data visually. A chart makes survey percentages much more impactful than a table alone.

WHERE TO FIND IT

Insert tab → Illustrations → Pictures → This Device. Browse to your chart screenshot and insert it. Place it in the Results section.

HOW YOU'LL KNOW IT WORKED

A bar chart image appears in the Results section.

2

Task 29 — Apply the "Reflected Rounded Rectangle" picture style to the chart image

WHY THIS MATTERS

A rounded rectangle with reflection adds a polished appearance to the figure, making it look like a professional data visualization.

WHERE TO FIND IT

Click the chart image. Picture Format tab → Picture Styles gallery → find "Reflected Rounded Rectangle" → click it.

HOW YOU'LL KNOW IT WORKED

The chart image has rounded corners and a subtle reflection below it.

2

Task 30 — Set text wrapping to "Top and Bottom" for the chart figure

WHY THIS MATTERS

"Top and Bottom" wrapping keeps the figure on its own horizontal strip, with text above and below but not beside it — the correct APA figure placement.

WHERE TO FIND IT

Click the image. Picture Format tab → Wrap Text → Top and Bottom.

HOW YOU'LL KNOW IT WORKED

No text appears to the left or right of the figure. Text flows above and below it.

3

Task 31 — Insert a SmartArt Cycle diagram showing the research process

WHY THIS MATTERS

A cycle diagram visualizes the iterative research process (Literature → Design → Collect → Analyze → Report → Literature) more effectively than words alone.

WHERE TO FIND IT

Insert tab → SmartArt → Cycle category → choose a cycle layout → OK. Enter each research process stage in the text pane.

HOW YOU'LL KNOW IT WORKED

A circular diagram appears with connected shapes representing each stage of the research process.

3

Task 32 — Add text to a shape to create a callout box highlighting a key statistic

WHY THIS MATTERS

Callout boxes draw attention to the most important data point, helping readers identify the key takeaway at a glance.

WHERE TO FIND IT

Insert tab → Illustrations → Shapes → Callouts category → choose a callout shape → draw it on the page. The shape is automatically selected for text entry — type your statistic.

HOW YOU'LL KNOW IT WORKED

A callout shape containing the statistic text appears on the page.

3

Task 33 — Position the callout shape in the right margin area

WHY THIS MATTERS

Placing the callout in the margin is a common typographical technique that keeps it visible without interrupting the reading flow.

WHERE TO FIND IT

Click the callout shape. Picture Format tab → Arrange → Position → choose a right-side position option. Or drag the shape to the right margin.

HOW YOU'LL KNOW IT WORKED

The callout shape sits in the right margin, not overlapping the main text column.

4

Task 34 — Add descriptive alt text to all figures in the document

WHY THIS MATTERS

Alt text is required for ADA-compliant academic documents and describes charts to students using screen readers.

WHERE TO FIND IT

Right-click each image and SmartArt → Edit Alt Text → type a description of what the figure shows and what it means.

HOW YOU'LL KNOW IT WORKED

Every visual element has descriptive alt text visible in the Alt Text pane.

D6 — Collaboration

14 points (6 tasks)

2

Task 35 — Add a comment on the thesis statement asking for professor feedback

WHY THIS MATTERS

Requesting feedback on a thesis statement before full submission is good academic practice and demonstrates engagement with the writing process.

WHERE TO FIND IT

Select the thesis statement text. Review tab → New Comment. Ask something specific like "Does this thesis clearly state my argument and methodology?"

HOW YOU'LL KNOW IT WORKED

A comment bubble appears connected to the thesis statement.

2

Task 36 — Reply to the existing comment from your writing partner

WHY THIS MATTERS

Responding to peer feedback shows you have reviewed suggestions and engaged in collaborative revision.

WHERE TO FIND IT

Find the writing partner comment in the sidebar. Click Reply. Type your response.

HOW YOU'LL KNOW IT WORKED

Your reply appears indented below the writing partner's original comment.

2

Task 37 — Resolve the comment after making the requested revision

WHY THIS MATTERS

Resolving the comment marks the issue as addressed and keeps the comment panel organized.

WHERE TO FIND IT

Click the comment → three-dot menu → Resolve Thread. Or right-click → Resolve Comment.

HOW YOU'LL KNOW IT WORKED

The comment appears grayed out / marked resolved.

3

Task 38 — Enable Track Changes and revise the Methodology section

WHY THIS MATTERS

Using Track Changes during peer review creates a transparent revision history that shows exactly what was changed.

WHERE TO FIND IT

Review tab → Track Changes → Track Changes (toggle on). Make revisions to the Methodology section.

HOW YOU'LL KNOW IT WORKED

Your edits in Methodology appear with colored markup (insertions underlined, deletions strikethrough).

2

Task 39 — Accept all tracked changes after peer review is complete

WHY THIS MATTERS

Accepting all changes incorporates the approved revisions permanently and prepares the document for submission.

WHERE TO FIND IT

Review tab → Changes group → Accept → Accept All Changes.

HOW YOU'LL KNOW IT WORKED

All markup disappears. The document text is clean with no colored edits visible.

3

Task 40 — Reject the tracked change that removed a required citation

WHY THIS MATTERS

A required citation was deleted in the tracked changes. Rejecting that specific change restores it to comply with APA citation requirements.

WHERE TO FIND IT

Review tab → Next to find the change that removed the citation. Click Reject (not Reject All) to restore only that deletion.

HOW YOU'LL KNOW IT WORKED

The citation text reappears in the document. Other changes are still accepted.